

Remote Work

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WHAT'S COVERED

In this lesson, you will learn about the movement to remote work and the unique ethical challenges it presents to employers and employees. Specifically, this lesson will cover:

1. Advantages of Remote Work



Technology has accelerated the globalization of business.

The term “**telecommuting**” (or “**telework**”) emerged in the 1970s to describe the practice of working at a specific location, whether the employee’s home or an alternate office, to reduce commuting time to a centrally located office. Telework was greatly facilitated by new telecommunications technology, including the internet, e-mail, and mobile phones. By the 2010s, the term “**remote work**” had replaced it, as the concept of working outside the office became more about virtual teams using newer technologies for conferencing and collaboration instead of email and occasional phone calls. The key technologies to making remote work more accessible are listed in the table below.

Technology	Description	Examples
Web Conferencing	Real-time audio-video meetings, often enhanced with a text chat, white board, screen sharing, and other features.	Google Meet Microsoft Teams WebEx Zoom
Cloud Applications	Software that stores documents and other tools on remote servers so people can access them from any device with web access for real-time collaboration.	Google Docs (standard office applications like word processing, spreadsheets, and slide decks) Microsoft Office 365 (standard office applications) Salesforce (data-based applications for sales, marketing, data analysis, etc.) Adobe Creative Suite (graphic arts applications)
Instant Messaging	Text-based chats, some with opportunities to share graphics, files, and other content; some use hashtags to help connect people in ad-hoc groups.	Discord Google Chat Microsoft Teams Slack
Remote Access	The ability to access a work-based computer remotely (using another computer), used in more secure work environments.	Native feature of Apple, Microsoft and Google Chrome devices.

Remote work was accelerated by the 2020 pandemic, when most office workers started working remotely during isolation, and has been further accelerated by the **gig economy**, an increase of temporary and part-time contract work instead of full-time permanent employment. As of 2023, approximately one worker in three works remotely at least some of the time.

Employers allow employees to work remotely for a variety of reasons. First, it is a powerful recruiting tool for people who want to balance their work and personal lives. It allows employees to work a more flexible schedule to care for children or older relatives while maintaining a career and earning income. It helps recruitment because every job search can be national or even global. Individuals with ability challenges such as mobility issues also prefer the flexibility that remote work affords them.

Remote work also reduces or eliminates the hours that employees spend traveling to and from the job and can help keep cars off the road. Fewer workers commuting equal less crowding on public transportation. Fewer cars mean less air pollution as well. The average U.S. employee (who commutes 30 miles and 60 minutes per day) will save more than \$1,000 on gas per year by not commuting (along with associated costs of parking and vehicle upkeep and insurance). Remote workers can continue to do their jobs despite weather conditions that impede travel. They are not exposed to sick coworkers' germs and may take fewer sick days. Remote employees are also seldom late for work when their workday starts at home.

There is a good deal of evidence suggesting that remote work has beneficial effects on worker productivity. Studies by individual companies like American Express as well as independent researchers like the *Harvard Business Review* have consistently found that remote workers are more productive, countering any suspicions that most workers take advantage of remote work to play games or watch television. While some might, overall remote work facilitates increased efficiency and productivity and also typically results in higher retention of workers, thereby reducing recruiting and training costs for firms.

Studies have shown that a person who commutes for an hour a day experiences added stress, anxiety, social isolation, and possibly depression. Perhaps that is why companies that implement remote work experience less absenteeism overall. It may also be easier to collaborate when not sharing a limited amount of space (such as cubicles), and people may be more willing to share resources with one another when the total number of workers present at the facility is reduced. Another point is that there may be less chatting and gossip among remote workers who are not in daily contact with each other or their colleagues.

Employers may be attracted to remote work for other reasons. Having remote employees can reduce office space costs. In fact, a company can consider expanding even when there is no available real estate or capital to enlarge or improve the physical facilities. Companies that hire remote employees can also widen their pool of potential applicants. They can choose recruits with better job skills than the local population can provide and expand their sales and marketing territory by hiring employees based in a new area.

Finally, there are many external environmental benefits of remote work. We have seen that a business that reduces total office space also reduces its impact on the environment. Remote workers would increase their individual consumption of utilities while working at home, but chances are that their home's energy consumption partially continues during the time spent at a traditional job anyway. For example, most people keep their house cooled or warmed while they're gone so it's comfortable when they return.

Employee Benefits	Employer Benefits	Other Benefits
Saves time	Reduces overhead (real estate in terms of office space rental, utilities, etc.)	Reduces greenhouse emissions
Reduces expenses for parking and transportation	Increases employee productivity.	Decreases energy dependence
Decreases stress	Decreases employee turnover	Improves DEI
Improves work-life balance (if well managed)		



REFLECT

How do you feel about remote work, if you have done it? Is it freeing to work at home or too distracting? Do you feel as connected to coworkers? To your manager? If you have not had the opportunity, do you wish you could work from home at least some of the time?



TERMS TO KNOW

Telecommunicating (Telework)

Now rarely used term for working outside of the office, connecting by occasional use of telephone and email.

Remote Work

More common term for working outside of the office, reflecting use of newer technologies that make communication and collaboration more constant within teams.

Gig Economy

The use by companies of more contract and temporary workers, meaning workers have short-term “gigs” instead of permanent employment.

Web Conferencing

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2. Drawbacks of Remote Work



How can remote work be implemented in an effective and ethical way?

Research suggests that employees collaborate more creatively when they meet to discuss projects face to face. This finding has important implications for firms dependent on research and development for their future growth. However, as technology improves and as workers become more familiar with it, real-time chats using tools like instant messaging can replace face-to-face meetings and even the kind of casual conversation that might spark innovation. Of course, the use of technology brings with it the need to ensure information security and protection against hacking, including guaranteeing the authenticity of the persons engaging via this technology as well as making sure that meetings are not interrupted by uninvited visitors.

Managers say that corporate culture is not easy to convey over distance. The remote worker might have developed certain working habits at a different company with a different corporate culture (sometimes in another country). It can be challenging to help employees adapt to the culture of a new company when they work remotely.

It is also more difficult for employers to monitor some kinds of work-related progress when an employee is working remotely. The likelihood of miscommunication increases when everything must be transmitted electronically or virtually. A manager cannot “manage by walking around” when the worker is remote. There are no incidental opportunities to witness a worker interacting with a client or customer. Workers may also be more hesitant to ask for direction on a project. Some managers worry that employees will slack off if there is no one there to watch them.

The remote worker may have qualms about privacy when his or her personal life inevitably intersects with the workday (as when a family member walks into the room or the dog barks during a conference call). Children may be confused when it seems like their parent is home but is not available for meals or play or homework help. It may be difficult for remote workers to maintain a work-life balance when their home becomes their office (especially if their hours are flexible). Workers may have to set aside living space for a home office and spend money to buy computing equipment, a desk, and other supplies.

➞ **EXAMPLE** A BBC News clip went viral in 2017 when an expert was interrupted by his children bursting into the room, revealing that his carefully staged office was at home.

Furthermore, it is difficult for an on-site technology team to provide technical assistance or secure data at the

level the company requires when people are working at home. Moreover, when the definition of the workplace begins to blur, who is responsible for injuries that occur on the job at home? The employer is unable to exercise the same control over safety measures that holds in a traditional workplace.

Quiet quitting, where employees gradually disengage and eventually quit their job without informing their employer, can also be more common in remote work situations. This may be due to the lack of face-to-face interactions and accountability, leading to a sense of disconnection from the company. Effective communication, regular check-ins, and creating a supportive work culture can help mitigate these issues and maintain engagement and productivity in remote work environments.



REFLECT

If you have done the same job at home and at the office, in which environment are you more productive? Not all fields are equally suited to remote work. Some jobs require consistent in-person contact with clients or customers, such as counseling, physical therapy, and medicine. Some industries need the highest computer security, such as banking and finance. Other work settings, such as law enforcement, have increased needs for building security that would make working remotely an unsafe alternative for employees.

The biggest drawback of remote work for the individual employee is the bias that studies reveal in employer attitudes. When some employees work remotely and others do not, those who are in the physical presence of the employer every day can more easily make an impression (good or bad) simply by interacting with their manager. There is also some indication that employees who opt for a nontraditional work arrangement may be penalized if they are perceived as lazy or less dedicated than those who maintain traditional work hours. Employers might have a stronger recollection of the work produced by the employee they see regularly than they do of the work a remote employee is submitting online. Therefore, promotions and important projects may go to employees who are more visible. The remote employee might eventually be left without equal footing in the push for increased pay and status.

While all of these are reasons to be wary of remote work, the pandemic of 2020 led to a seismic shift in perceptions. During the period of stay-at-home orders and isolation, workers found themselves able to do their job completely from home, becoming more adept at the technology, and managers also came to understand this was possible. This will be covered more in a later tutorial.



TERM TO KNOW

Quiet Quitting

The process of disengaging from work and eventually quitting completely without giving proper notice to the employer.

3. Ethical Challenges of Remote Work

To summarize, even a manager who is not prejudiced against remote work has a number of ethical challenges, including:

- Deciding which workers may work remotely, if some staff must work on-site.
- Giving remote workers fair performance reviews and the same opportunities for advancement.
- Maintaining security of remote worker's work-related data.
- Fostering a high level of collaboration among teams.

To help, managers should also set up a framework of policies to govern at-home work and ensure fairness.

For example, there could be a standard for how much time each person should spend in the office. Managers should set clear expectations for remote workers, such as maintaining professionalism in dress and work environment, and meeting deadlines. In the interests of fairness and equity, neither expectations nor rewards should differ from those established for in-house workers.



BIG IDEA

Remote work is more likely to succeed when remote employees are provided with the right technology, are empowered by inclusion in the corporate culture, and interact with colleagues in a manner that clearly expresses their expectations, values, and trust.

One area that is a special challenge for managers of remote workers is training and mentorship; traditionally, workers have been able to acclimate quickly by “shadowing” a person who has the same job, and have direct supervision as they begin working themselves, with frequent constructive feedback. Remotely, this is less likely to happen, and a new employee may have to learn as they go with only occasional check-ins. This may set them up for failure, especially if they are newer workers without similar experience to draw on or are not skilled at time management.

To help guard against the risk that remote employees will be unfairly considered “out of sight, out of mind,” the ethical company will adopt written expectations about timely communication in both directions. For instance, it should ensure that managers’ lines of communication are as open to their remote employees as they are to those who can drop by their desk or office to chat. IM tools like Google Chat can help replace the kind of “open door” policy a manager might have in the office, provided the manager is responsive to questions and the new employee is willing to use it.

For jobs with needs for high security, remote work presents a challenge. Employees working from home or in public places need to assure that they are using a secure internet connection and information being passed through the network cannot be compromised. They must also take precautions that their computers cannot be accessed by unauthorized people, which may be difficult if they share their computer with family. Security is especially important for people who work in finance, health, and education, and other fields where laws and ethics require special care with private information. This may require training all staff on the use of a **virtual private network (VPN)**, which essentially simulates connecting to the work network as if they were in the office and encrypts data being transferred either to or from the network. Further training is also needed for all staff to be cautious about opening emails or following links that might include malware that gives bad agents access to their computer.

Finally, many firms with successful remote work programs create a social network among employees. They sponsor online social occasions to help employees bond even though they are not in the same place. Workers can then find a way to have some virtual fun, despite the distance that might separate them. For example, in a team chat, people can share funny customer interactions. They may even talk about the local sports team, the weather, or other small topics they would in the break room at a traditional office environment.



TERM TO KNOW

Virtual Private Network (VPN)

A tool that allows a remote computer to connect securely to an on-site network by encrypting data being transferred to or from the network.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you learned about the **advantages of remote work**, including flexibility, cost savings on commuting, and increased productivity due to reduced distractions. However, **remote work has drawbacks**, like the potential for **social isolation** and lack of meaningful relationships and interactions at work. **Ethical challenges of remote work** for employers include ensuring fair treatment of remote workers and protecting sensitive information. For remote workers, concerns include honest reporting of hours and maintaining work-life balance. Companies must develop effective policies to ensure the success and well-being of their remote workforce.

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TERMS TO KNOW

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Gig Economy

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